



KAUR'S Gospel

ON MANMOHAN:
 "To run the Government is no joke. He tries his best and works very hard."

ON EDUCATION:
 "Girls are the worst sufferers. They are undervalued and drop out of school."

ON PRICE HIKES:
 "If businessmen are more honest and avoid hoarding, we'll be better off."

would never be in favour of a hike in the prices of LPG. But this is a compulsion of the government and the only way to tide it over is that we all get together and make a sacrifice."

Just as we have a more confident and assertive Manmohan in office in his second stint as prime minister, so do we have a more visible First Lady by his side. Of late she has become a familiar figure even without her husband by her side, attending charity events, book release functions and speaking against child labour at a UNICEF event. The printed salwar-kameez that she wore when she was the finance minister's wife has been replaced with silk saris in elegant pastels, but at heart she remains the spirited lass from Jalandhar. Friends are greeted with a warm "Sat Sri Akal" (traditional Sikh greeting) when they answer her phone call and sometimes—if she likes the caller tune on their mobile—a complaint that they took the call too soon.

During her 72nd birthday this year, Isher Ahluwalia, one of her closest friends in bureaucratic Delhi, threw a party for her. There were just a dozen women friends, most of them from her school days. As per the birthday girl's wishes, they played passing the parcel. When a friend was hesitant to perform a penalty dance, Gursharan quickly got up to twirl with her. They also sang songs; not the Bollywood variety but Punjabi folk. "She is the kind of person who has no

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